

# A Multiple Linear Regression Model for NBA MVP since 2000

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## 1 Introduction

At the end of every NBA Regular Season, a selection of NBA media personnel vote on a plethora of awards. None of these awards are more prestigious than the Most Valuable Player Award. This award has been the center of much controversy over the years, whether it be people a certain player was robbed of the award or if the award means anything at all. Many models have been made before to attempt predict the MVP based on various statistics collected throughout the season. These models have been near perfect, almost being able to predict every MVP. Most of the models attribute their error to media influence/narratives, because on-the-court play statistics does not account for this. This model makes an attempt to quantify the media influence on the MVP race in order to eliminate this error. The model developed correctly predicts every MVP from 2000-2026, and uses Multiple Linear Regression of different statistics and media influence to determine who WILL win(not should win) the MVP Award.

## 2 Media in the MVP Award

The NBA MVP award is voted on by a panel of sportswriters and media personnel. This means that MVP is not a completely objective award, there is no statistical formula the NBA uses to determine the MVP. The formula used in this paper that correctly predicts MVP from 2000-2026, although accurate, is not what they use to determine MVP. With this in mind, it is no surprise that discourse in the media can shape who wins the MVP Award. This takes the form of "narratives," or popular ideas that spread around and are major talking points. These can be positive or negative, and usually involve a team's record, a player's individual decisions, or a record being broken. Due to this, often times the consensus best player in the league does not win the MVP. Examples of these can include Steve Nash in 2005 leading the Suns to the best record in the NBA after being one of the worst teams, LeBron James in 2011 after "The Decision," and Russell Westbrook in 2017 after becoming the first player since

Oscar Robertson to average a Triple-Double. In terms of negative narratives, often times the topic of 'voter fatigue' comes up. This is when a player who has won multiple MVP's in a row has it harder to win another MVP because the media is 'tired' of voting for them. This is seen with Tim Duncan in 2004, Giannis Antetokounmpo in 2021, and Nikola Jokic in 2023. In a similar token, team dominance over an extended period of team can also lead to a similar outcome. Dominance over a long period of team in any facet can very much hurt your MVP narrative in the media. Now that media influence has been introduced, the next section will discuss the Media Statistic for the model and explain how it is used.

### 3 The Media Statistic

As described earlier, there are positive and negative media narratives that influence the MVP race. To some extent, every MVP race is influenced by media; this does not mean that the effect is necessary to account for every year. For example, the 2026 race between Shai-Gilgeous Alexander, Nikola Jokic, and Victor Wembanyama, did not have a specific media narrative that influenced the decision to any specific person. The distinction being the media having an influence with a narrative versus having an influence without a narrative is very important. With that said, narratives are the basis for the media statistic used in the model. Each player in the last 27 years was evaluated and a question was asked: What media narratives were in play for your MVP case that year?. Once that question was determined for each player, a follow-up question was asked for each narrative : Was that narrative positive or negative? Lastly, to determine the final stat, the number of positive narratives was subtracted by the number of negative narratives. For example, the 2017 MVP Race with Russell Westbrook, he had 2 positive narratives. Firstly, the Triple-Double Push as mentioned prior. Secondly, in the offseason prior, Kevin Durant left the OKC Thunder with Westbrook to join the 73-9 Warriors, forming one of the greatest superteams ever. The media felt bad for Westbrook considering the OKC Thunder the previous year nearly beat that same Warriors team. Below are a list of all the narratives considered for the media statistic:

- 2000 Shaquille O'Neal - The media was blown away by the utter dominance of the 7' Shaquille O'Neal, who averaged 29.7 PTS, 13.6 REB, and 3.0 BLK while leading the Lakers to 67 Wins. They were quick to anoint a new best player in the league after Michael Jordan retired.
- 2001 Allen Iverson - The media saw Allen Iverson take an underdog 76ers to the Number 1 Seed in the Eastern Conference, as well as his legendary dribbling ability, and loved him. This, combined with leading the league in scoring and steals led him to get a very positive media narrative in the 2001 season.
- 2002 Shaquille O'Neal - The first negative in the 21st century, after winning 2 championships, tensions were rising between Kobe Bryant and

Shaquille O'Neal. Both were having trouble coexisting as top players in the league on the same team. This rivalry both players in a negative light during this season, and the media was keen on focusing on this, hurting Shaq's MVP narrative.

- Tim Duncan 2004 - This is a voter fatigue narrative. Tim Duncan won the MVP in 2002 and 2003; any back to back MVP during this era has a negative media narrative factored in.
- Steve Nash 2005 - This is the first time two separate narratives were present. Firstly, Steve Nash led the Suns on one of the most impressive turnarounds in NBA history, going from 29 to 62 wins. However, the other narrative was that the offense the Suns were running was revolutionary at the time. There was a quicker pace, more 3-Point Shooting, and a dynamic transition and pick-and-roll offense. This new style took the media by storm and they were thrilled with it.
- Shaquille O'Neal 2005 - The tensions between Kobe Bryant and Shaquille O'Neal that influenced the 2002 MVP race boiled over after their 2004 finals loss to the Detroit Pistons. Shaq left for the Miami Heat to team up with Dwayne Wade, and the media viewed Shaq and Kobe negatively due to this beef.
- Steve Nash 2006 - After his historic 2005 season, the Suns were poised to run it back for success in 2006. However, early on in the season, his All-Star teammate Amar'e Stoudemire got injured. Steve Nash still led the team to 2nd place in the Western Conference despite the injury, and the media loved how he was able to maintain the new offensive style that debuted in 2005 basically by himself.
- Steve Nash 2007 - Steve Nash after the 2006 season now had voter fatigue because he had won back to back MVP awards. This ultimately hurt him for his chance of a 3-peat.
- Kobe Bryant 2008 - By the time 2008 rolled around, many media members had said Kobe was overdue for an MVP and he 'deserved' one, referencing close calls in 2006 and 2007. As well as this, he had a second positive media narrative in the fact that for the first time since 2004 with Shaq, his team finished well in the regular season. These two factors combined helped Kobe have a huge media advantage for his 2008 season.
- LeBron James 2011 - LeBron James was considered one of the best players in the league, winning back to back MVP's in 2009 and 2010. This though, comes with the media voter fatigue narrative. However, in the offseason after the 2010 season, LeBron left his hometown team the Cavaliers to join the Miami Heat with Dwayne Wade and Chris Bosh in what was known as 'The Decision'. This left a very sour taste in the media's mouth, and therefore added a second negative media narrative to LeBron's 2011 season.

- Derrick Rose 2011 - The young explosive guard playing for a franchise in the Chicago Bulls that had not been relevant since the time of Michael Jordan took the city by storm. The Bulls, in an Eastern Conference with the LeBron, Dwyane Wade, and Chris Bosh lead Miami Heat, and the Big 3 Celtics featuring Kevin Garnett, Paul Pierce, and Rajon Rondo, finished first. With this, the media took sympathy and loved Derrick Rose, giving him a huge positive media narrative.
- LeBron James 2013 - This is widely regarded as one of the best individual seasons of basketball ever played, as LeBron James dominated the league both offensively and defensively. The media was blown away by the sheer dominance of LeBron this season, and there was no question in their eyes who the best player in the world was. This ultimately led to him having the narrative as a "Lock for MVP".
- LeBron James 2014 - At this point, LeBron James had won back-to-back MVP's, so unfortunately the media had voter fatigue in regards to him. This year, he had a negative media narrative.
- Stephen Curry 2016 - Coming off a championship in 2015, the Warriors were the most dominant team in basketball, winning 73 games this season, an NBA record. Steph Curry was the catalyst for this run, leading the team, giving him one of the best team-performance narratives ever. As well as this, he also set an NBA-record for 3-Pointers made in a season, over 400. The media was regarding it as one of the best individual seasons ever, comparing it 2013 LeBron and 1987 Jordan. This gave Curry 2 positive narratives.
- Russell Westbrook 2017 - As explained previously, Westbrook had 2 positive narratives helping his case. The media felt sympathy for him when Kevin Durant left the Thunder for the Warriors, leaving Russ to carry the load. As well as this, Russell Westbrook averaged a triple-double this year, and the media was enthralled by this.
- 2021 Giannis Antetokounmpo - Giannis had won the MVP in 2019 and 2020, therefore in 2021 he had the negative voter fatigue narrative.
- 2023 Joel Embiid - Joel Embiid had come second to Nikola Jokic in the last 2 MVP races, with some in hindsight thinking Joel Embiid deserved one of the previous awards. The media was very much pushing that it was Joel Embiid's year in 2023, as he was averaging nearly 35 PPG. In essence, his positive narrative was similar to 2008 Kobe as both were considered overdue.
- 2023 Nikola Jokic - Jokic, after winning back to back MVP's, had the same voter fatigue negative narrative that plagued LeBron, Giannis, Steve Nash, and Tim Duncan previously.

## 4 Model Creation and Results

To determine what factors typically work, analyzed first using Multiple Linear Regression was 2010 and onward. From this, PRA(the combination of a player's points, rebounds, and assists), their teams win-percentage, and the Media Statistic(labeled Media) were the ones that were most important and deemed statistically significant by the model. And after conducting Multiple Linear Regression using the whole dataset(2000 on), those were the factors that end up being the determinant in creating a model that predicted ALL of the MVP's from 2000 on.

## 5 Sources

1. Basketball Reference MVP Data
2. Basketball Reference Standings Data